

Little Cloud's Big Rainstorm

A story about feelings, emotions, and why it's okay to cry

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

Dedication

To every child who has been told to stop crying your tears are not weakness. They are rain that helps you grow.

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Up in the sky, above the tallest mountains and below the smiling sun, there lived a little cloud named Cumulus.

Cumulus was the smallest cloud in the sky family. He was round and fluffy and white, and he loved floating along on the breeze.

All around him, the big clouds did their important jobs – carrying rain to the farmers' fields, bringing snow to the mountains, making thunder for the storms.

But Cumulus had never rained. Not once. And he was determined to keep it that way.

[Illustration: A small, round, fluffy white cloud floating in a bright blue sky, surrounded by larger clouds, looking cheerful but slightly tense, trying to hold everything in]

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You see, Cumulus thought that raining was embarrassing.

When the big clouds rained, they got smaller. They went from bright white to heavy gray.

Sometimes they even rumbled and cried out with thunder.

'I don't want to get all dark and heavy,' Cumulus told himself. 'I want to stay white and light and happy forever!'

So whenever he felt water droplets building up inside him whenever he felt the rain wanting to come he squeezed tight and held it all in.

[Illustration: Cumulus watching a large gray cloud raining heavily below, looking uncomfortable and turning away, squeezing himself smaller to hold in the moisture building inside him]

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His mother, a beautiful cloud named Nimbus, noticed. 'Cumulus, darling, you look a little heavy today. Do you need to rain?'

'NO!' Cumulus said quickly. 'I'm fine! I'm totally fine! See? Still white! Still light!'

But he wasn't fine. He was getting heavier and heavier inside, holding more and more water that needed to fall.

His edges were turning gray, but he tried to puff himself up white to hide it.

[Illustration: Mother cloud Nimbus, soft and beautiful, looking concerned at Cumulus who is visibly getting heavier and slightly gray at the edges, puffing himself up to appear okay]

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Days passed. Cumulus kept holding everything in. And he kept getting heavier. He couldn't float as high anymore. He sank lower in the sky, barely above the treetops. The breeze that used to carry him easily now struggled. 'Whew, you're getting heavy, little one!' the wind said.

'I'm FINE,' Cumulus insisted stubbornly, even as he dipped lower and lower. But inside, he felt awful. Tight. Heavy. Like he might burst at any moment.

[Illustration: Cumulus floating very low in the sky, visibly heavy and dark gray, just above the treetops, struggling to stay up, the wind looking strained trying to carry him]

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One morning, Cumulus looked down and saw something terrible.

Below him was a beautiful valley, but it was bone dry. The flowers were wilting. The grass was turning brown.

The river was just a trickle. The animals gathered around the last puddle, thirsty and tired.

A farmer looked up at the sky desperately. 'Please, clouds we need rain! The crops are dying!'

Cumulus felt his water shift inside him. His rain wanted to fall. But he held tighter.

[Illustration: A dried-out valley below with wilting flowers, brown grass, and thirsty animals by a nearly dry river, a farmer looking up hopefully at the sky, Cumulus floating above full of water but refusing to release it]

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'Why don't you just let go?' asked a passing cloud named Drizzle.

'I can't,' Cumulus said. 'If I rain, I'll get all dark and small and everyone will see my feelings.'

'What's wrong with that?' Drizzle asked gently. 'I rain every other day. It feels wonderful like a big exhale after holding your breath.'

'It looks... messy,' Cumulus said. 'And weak. Strong clouds don't need to rain.'

Drizzle shook her misty head. 'Oh, Cumulus. You have it backwards. Holding it ALL in? THAT'S what will hurt you.'

[Illustration: A gentle gray cloud named Drizzle talking to the heavy, struggling Cumulus, Drizzle looking concerned and wise, trying to convince Cumulus to let go]

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That night, Cumulus sank so low he was resting on the top of a hill. He was so heavy he couldn't move.

A little girl was sitting on that hill, crying. Tears streamed down her face.

'What's wrong?' Cumulus asked softly.

'My dog is very sick,' the girl said through her tears. 'I'm so sad. I keep crying and I can't stop.'

'Aren't you embarrassed?' Cumulus asked. 'People can see you crying.'

[Illustration: Cumulus resting heavily on a hilltop, too heavy to float, a young girl sitting nearby crying, both of them dealing with heavy feelings, a twilight scene]

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The girl wiped her eyes and looked at him. 'My mom says crying is like rain for the heart.'

'What does that mean?' Cumulus asked.

'It means feelings need to come out. If you hold them in too long, they get heavy and hurt.' She sniffled. 'After I cry, I always feel a little better. Lighter.'

Cumulus felt something crack inside him. Lighter. That's all he wanted to feel. Light again.

'But isn't crying... weak?' he asked in a tiny voice.

[Illustration: Close-up of the girl and Cumulus talking, the girl wisely explaining about tears and rain, Cumulus listening intently, understanding dawning on his face]

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'Crying is the bravest thing there is,' the girl said. 'My dad told me that. It means you're strong enough to feel your feelings instead of hiding them.'

She smiled through her tears. 'I'd rather cry than hold it all inside until I feel like I'm going to explode.'

Cumulus looked at her this small, brave human who wasn't ashamed of her tears.

And he thought about himself a cloud so afraid of rain that he was crushing himself to hold it in.

'Maybe...' he whispered. 'Maybe it's time.'

[Illustration: The girl reaching out to touch Cumulus who is now nearly on the ground, both of them sharing a moment of understanding, stars beginning to appear in the sky]

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Cumulus rose back into the sky one final push of effort and floated above the dry, thirsty valley.

He looked down at the wilting flowers, the thirsty animals, the desperate farmer.

They needed his rain. The world NEEDED what he'd been holding in.

He took a deep breath... and let go.

For the first time in his life, Cumulus let the rain fall.

[Illustration: Cumulus floating above the dry valley, taking a deep breath, the moment before letting go, a dramatic pause before the rain comes, moonlight and stars around him]

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And oh, what a rain it was!

Not a drizzle, not a sprinkle a magnificent, glorious downpour. Weeks and weeks of held-in rain came pouring out all at once.

Cumulus turned dark gray, then purple with the effort. Thunder rumbled from deep inside him all the feelings he'd kept locked away.

Lightning flickered the sparks of emotion finally being released.

It was loud. It was messy. It was overwhelming. And it was BEAUTIFUL.

[Illustration: A dramatic rainstorm unleashed from Cumulus heavy rain pouring down, lightning flickering, thunder rumbling a powerful emotional release depicted as a magnificent storm]

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Below him, the world came alive!

The flowers lifted their heads and drank. The grass turned green almost instantly.

The river swelled and sang again. Animals danced in the puddles.

The farmer fell to his knees with joy. 'RAIN! Beautiful rain! Our crops are saved!'

Everything Cumulus had held inside every drop he thought was embarrassing was exactly what the world needed.

[Illustration: The valley transformed by the rain flowers blooming, river flowing, animals playing in puddles, the farmer celebrating with arms raised, everything coming back to life beautifully]

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When the rain finally stopped, Cumulus felt... incredible.

He was lighter than he'd been in weeks. The heaviness was gone. The tight, compressed feeling had melted away.

He looked at himself – smaller now, yes, and still a little gray at the edges. But he could float again! High and free!

It was exactly what the girl had described. Like a big exhale after holding your breath for too, too long.

'That felt AMAZING,' Cumulus said, doing a little spin in the breeze.

[Illustration: Cumulus after the rain – smaller and lighter, floating high in the sky again, spinning happily, light gray but with a huge smile, feeling relieved and free]

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His mother Nimbus floated over and wrapped herself around him in a warm, misty hug.

'I'm so proud of you,' she said. 'That was a beautiful rain, my love.'

'I was scared,' Cumulus admitted. 'I thought raining would make me weak.'

'Oh, sweetheart,' Nimbus said. 'Raining is the bravest thing a cloud can do. It's sharing yourself with the world. It makes everything grow.'

'Holding it in forever THAT'S what was making you sick.'

[Illustration: Mother cloud Nimbus wrapping around little Cumulus in a warm misty embrace, both smiling, the sky blue and calm after the storm, a comforting mother-child moment]

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From that day on, Cumulus rained whenever he needed to.

Sometimes it was a gentle drizzle on a quiet afternoon. Sometimes it was a thunderstorm when big feelings built up.

Sometimes it was just a few drops and that was okay too.

He learned that every kind of rain was normal. Every kind of feeling was valid.

And after every rain, he always felt lighter, fresher, and ready to float high again.

[Illustration: A sequence showing Cumulus in different states light drizzle, thunderstorm, gentle rain all perfectly natural and healthy, ending with him floating happily after each one]

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And the valley below? It became the most lush, green, alive place in the world.

Because Cumulus rained when he needed to, the flowers always had water. The crops always grew. The river always flowed.

His feelings his rain didn't just help HIM. They helped everything around him grow.

That's the secret no one tells you about tears: they don't just empty you out. They water the garden of your life.

[Illustration: The valley below absolutely thriving and green and lush, all because Cumulus learned to rain regularly, a paradise of growth fed by healthy emotional release]

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Cumulus even learned that different feelings make different kinds of rain.

Sadness made gentle, steady rain that helped flowers grow slowly and strong.

Frustration made quick thunderstorms that cleared the air and made room for sunshine.

Joy made sparkling mist that painted rainbows across the sky.

Every feeling had its own weather, and every weather was needed and beautiful.

[Illustration: Different types of rain from Cumulus gentle rain growing flowers, a quick thunderstorm clearing air, sparkling mist creating rainbows all beautiful and purposeful]

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One day, Cumulus met another small cloud who was holding in his rain just like he used to. 'I can't let anyone see me cry,' the little cloud said, puffing up to hide his gray edges. Cumulus floated beside him gently. 'I used to think that too. Want to know what happened to me?'

He told his whole story the holding, the heaviness, the girl on the hill, and finally letting go.

'After I rained,' Cumulus said, 'I felt the best I'd ever felt. Lighter than air. Try it. I'll rain with you.'

[Illustration: Cumulus floating beside another small puffy cloud who looks heavy and gray, talking gently to him, offering to rain together, a supportive friend helping another open up]

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Together, the two clouds rained side by side. The little cloud's first rain was small and timid.

But Cumulus cheered him on: 'That's it! Let it go! You're doing great!'

The little cloud rained harder, and harder, until a beautiful storm poured down together from both of them.

Afterward, the little cloud was light and floating high. 'That felt INCREDIBLE! Why did I wait so long?'

'We all wait too long,' Cumulus smiled. 'But it's never too late to let it out.'

[Illustration: Two clouds raining together side by side, supporting each other, both looking relieved and happy afterward, floating high and light, a buddy system for emotional expression]

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The little girl on the hill? Her dog got better. And she still visited Cumulus whenever he floated low.

'Thank you,' she told him once. 'Watching you rain taught me something too.'

'What's that?' Cumulus asked.

'That everyone needs to let their feelings out even big, strong clouds. It doesn't make us weak. It makes us real.'

They sat together in comfortable silence, the girl and the cloud, two beings who understood that feelings are meant to flow, not to be dammed up inside.

[Illustration: The girl sitting on her hill, healthy dog beside her, waving up at Cumulus who floats happily above, both peaceful and emotionally healthy, a warm friendship scene]

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Cumulus also learned when to ask for help. Sometimes his feelings were too big for just rain.

On those days, he'd float to his mother Nimbus, or find Drizzle, or seek out the girl on the hill.

'I'm having a really hard day,' he'd say. And they would simply be there with him.

He learned that you don't always have to weather the storm alone. Sometimes the bravest thing is saying: I need help. I need someone to be with me.

And there was always someone willing to be there.

[Illustration: Cumulus with friends around him on a hard day Nimbus nearby, Drizzle, the girl below supported and not alone, showing that asking for help is also okay]

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So here's what Cumulus wants you to know, little reader:

It's okay to cry. It's okay to feel sad, or angry, or scared, or overwhelmed.

Those feelings are not weakness they are rain. And rain makes things grow.

Don't hold everything in until you feel like you're going to burst. Let it out. Cry if you need to. Talk about it. Express it.

After every storm, the sky is clearer. After every cry, your heart is lighter. That's just how it works.

[Illustration: A child reading this book, perhaps with tears in their eyes, realizing it's okay to feel and express emotions, a gentle and validating final image with a rainbow after rain]

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Here is your permission slip, signed by Cumulus himself:

You are allowed to cry. You are allowed to feel angry. You are allowed to be sad.

You are allowed to have big feelings that feel too big for your body.

You are allowed to need a hug, need a friend, need to talk, or need to be alone.

All of it is okay. All of it is natural. All of it makes you beautifully, wonderfully human.

[Illustration: A permission slip drawn beautifully with cloud borders, giving children permission to feel all their feelings, signed with a cloud stamp, warm and validating and empowering]

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And after the rain comes the rainbow. After the tears comes the lightness. After the storm comes the clearest sky you have ever seen.

So let it rain when it needs to. Let the feelings flow.

You are not broken. You are not weak. You are a cloud doing exactly what clouds are meant to do.

And the garden of your life will be all the more beautiful for every drop of rain that falls.

Rain on, little cloud. Rain on.

[Illustration: A magnificent rainbow arching across the sky after a rainstorm, Cumulus floating happily and lightly above it, the valley below green and alive, a hopeful and beautiful final image]

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One last thing Cumulus wants you to remember:

If someone you love is holding in their rain if someone seems heavy and struggling be gentle with them.

You can be their safe place. You can say: 'It is okay to cry. I am here. I will not think less of you.'

Sometimes the kindest thing you can do for someone is give them permission to let their feelings out.

Be a safe sky for other people's clouds. That is one of the greatest gifts you can give.

[Illustration: Two children sitting together, one crying and the other with an arm around them providing comfort, showing that being a safe space for others' feelings is a beautiful gift]

The Moral of the Story

It's Okay to Cry - Emotions Are Natural and Helpful

Cumulus learned that holding in your feelings doesn't make you strong it makes you heavy. Tears, like rain, are natural and necessary. They help you process hard feelings, release tension, and make room for happiness again. Everyone cries sometimes even grown-ups, even tough people, even clouds! After you let your feelings out, you always feel lighter. So never be ashamed of your tears. They are proof that you feel deeply, and that is a beautiful thing.

Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. When was the last time you cried? Did you feel better afterward?
2. Why do you think some people say 'don't cry' or 'be strong'? Do you agree that crying IS being strong?
3. What are some ways to express feelings besides crying? (Talking, drawing, running, etc.)
4. How did Cumulus's rain help the valley below? How might your feelings help people around you?
5. What would you say to a friend who was embarrassed about crying?

About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.